Construction CRM Deep Dive

What a CRM for a design-build remodeler like Levi Homes must have, what separates the leaders, and how Eagle I can beat all of them by automating as much of the client's work as possible. Prepared October 14, 2026 from vendor sites, review platforms (Capterra, G2), trade press and industry surveys. Prices are third-party reported and change often.

The short version

The market is split in two, and nobody owns the middle. The leaders (Buildertrend, JobTread, Houzz Pro) are *production* systems: estimating, schedules, budgets, change orders, client portals. Their CRM is a thin front door that waits for leads to arrive. The sales-first CRMs (MarketSharp, improveit 360, Builder Prime, Leap) are good at follow-up but reviewers describe them as dated. **None of them generate demand.** Eagle I already does: permits, aging-system homes, storm signals, verified referral-partner directories, landing pages, ads. The opportunity is one **self-standing** platform that **finds** the job, **wins** it, **builds** it and **keeps** the client for life, so a remodeler needs no Buildertrend, JobTread or Houzz Pro alongside it.

Design principle: the client only does what only a person can do: meet the homeowner, design, price, build, and approve. Everything else runs on its own, under rules they approve once. The leaders automate *reminders*; Eagle I should automate the *work*.

Who we are building for

Levi Homes is a Houston design-build and luxury remodeling firm (1001 S. Dairy Ashford, West Houston / Energy Corridor) with a GuildQuality profile. Firms like this share a sales shape that generic CRMs handle badly:

- **Few, large, slow deals.** Luxury remodels run long sales cycles (weeks to months) with several meetings, so a missed follow-up costs a five- or six-figure job, not a $300 service call.
- **Two contracts, not one.** Design-build firms sell a *paid design / pre-construction agreement* first, then the construction contract. Industry sales playbooks (JLC, Remodelers Advantage) describe stages: qualify, site visit, design agreement, design + estimating, preliminary proposal, construction contract. Most CRMs only model “lead → proposal → won.”
- **Budget fit decides everything.** The costliest mistake is a two-hour site visit with a homeowner whose budget is a third of the scope. Qualifying before the visit matters more than raw lead count.
- **Business comes from people they already know.** Industry surveys put repeats and referrals at roughly 37% (NAHB) to almost 80% (Pro Remodeler Business Results) of remodelers' leads; about 12% come from other professionals such as architects and trades.
- **The homeowner experience is the product.** At this price point, communication during the job drives reviews and referrals, which drive the next job.

Part 1: The basics every construction CRM needs

These are table stakes. A CRM missing any of them won't be taken seriously by a remodeler evaluating it next to Buildertrend or JobTread.

Basic	What it means in practice	Eagle I today
Contact + property record	Person, household, and the **house** (address, type, age, value). Lead source captured on every record.	Partial: leads and past customers exist; no unified contact/property record

Basic	What it means in practice	Eagle I today
Lead capture from every channel	Web forms, phone, email, Houzz/Angi/Thumbtack, referrals, walk-ins, all landing in one inbox. Duplicate detection.	Landing-page forms only
Pipeline with custom stages	Visual board; stages match the firm's real process; deal value + expected close date.	Leads have 4 statuses; vendor relationships have stages
Tasks, reminders, calendar	Next step on every open deal; site-visit scheduling; overdue flags.	Next follow-up date on vendor relationships only
Communication log	Every email, text and call tied to the contact. Two-way texting is now expected.	Email history + reply capture; no texting
Automated follow-up	Instant acknowledgment, drip sequences, stop-on-reply.	Yes (lead sequence, follow-ups, stop rules)
Estimates & proposals	Cost catalog, templates, branded proposal, **e-signature**, deposit collection.	No
Files & photos per job	Plans, contracts, site photos, permits on the record.	Photo requests + Work With Us uploads only
Sales-to-production hand-off	Signed proposal becomes the job budget / schedule with no retyping.	No
Reporting	Lead source ROI, close rate, pipeline value, response time, win/loss reasons.	Strong marketing + outreach reports; no sales funnel reports
Mobile app	Field and sales staff work from the truck.	Web only (mobile-responsive)
Accounting sync	QuickBooks Online at minimum.	No
Client portal	Homeowner sees status, documents, selections, payments.	No

Read-across: Eagle I already has the hard, unglamorous parts of a CRM that most startups skip (consent, opt-outs, bounce handling, send windows, deliverability, reply classification). The biggest gaps are the record model (contact + property + deal), proposals with e-signature, texting, and the sales-funnel reports.

Part 2: The leaders and what sets them apart

Platform	Reported price	Where it wins	Where users complain
Buildertrend (absorbed CoConstruct)	~$339–$1,099/mo, flat, unlimited users; quote-only	Broadest all-in-one; strong scheduling, change orders, POs; Customer Portal. Sep 29, 2026: AI Client Updates, AI Bill Capture, AI Plans, AI Submittals; bought BizJet AI (Jul 2026) for agentic AI.	Price, heavy onboarding, dated UI with buried features, weak field time tracking; reports of price jumps and contract/refund disputes
JobTread	$199/mo incl. 1 user, +$20/user ($159 + $16 annual)	Fastest-rising; best-in-class estimating and budget-vs-actual; clean UI; customer portal with selections + online payments; support rated exceptional (4.9 Capterra, 5.0 G2).	Contract management is basic; QuickBooks is the only accounting integration; CRM side is light
Houzz Pro	~$65–$99+/mo, annual, non-cancellable	Only one bundled with a consumer lead marketplace; 3D floor planner; Houzz AI takeoffs, voice-to-estimate, receipt capture, AI change orders and invoices.	Lead quality (“~2 leads a month, mostly poor”); auto-renewal and cancellation fights; shallow depth
Buildxact	~$189/mo	Fast on-screen digital takeoff tied to estimating	Takeoff learning curve; limited mobile
MarketSharp / improveit 360	Quote-only, annual	Built for home-improvement *sales*: lead management, appointment setting, past-client marketing, profitability dashboards	“2008-era” / Salesforce-era interfaces, long setup, expensive for small firms

Platform	Reported price	Where it wins	Where users complain
Builder Prime / Leap / JobNimbus	~$79+/mo to quote-only	Speed-to-lead automation, SMS/email nurture, in-home sales tools, payments; JobNimbus has best-in-class custom boards	Skewed to roofing/exterior and high-volume in-home sales, not luxury design-build
HubSpot / generic CRMs	Free–$100/user/mo	Polished, easy, great automation	No estimates, selections, change orders or job concepts

The six things that separate the top tier

- **One continuous record from lead to final invoice.** The #1 complaint in the category is double entry across spreadsheets, PDFs and apps. JobTread and Buildertrend win because the estimate becomes the contract, the budget, the POs and the invoices without retyping.
- **The homeowner portal.** Selections and allowances, change orders with e-signature, progress photos, online payments. Reviewers single it out for cutting down "panicked phone calls."
- **Job costing you can trust.** Budget vs. actual is why remodelers move to JobTread. Profit known during the job, not after.
- **AI that removes admin.** In 2026 this is the main battleground: Houzz AI does takeoffs and voice estimates ("20 seconds vs. an hour"); Buildertrend drafts client updates and reads bills. Every leader is now promising agentic AI.
- **Pricing and support people trust.** JobTread's transparent per-user pricing and live support are a big part of its ratings lead; Buildertrend and Houzz Pro lose stars mainly on contracts and billing.
- **An ecosystem.** QuickBooks, CompanyCam, EagleView, supplier ordering, financing. Nobody wants to rip out the tools their crews already use.

Where all of them fall short

- **They wait for leads.** Lead management means capturing what already arrived. None source jobs from permits, home data, weather or partner networks. Houzz's marketplace is the exception, and its quality is the top complaint.
- **Slow response is left to humans.** The Lead Response Management study (HBR, 15,000+ leads) found leads called within 5 minutes were 21x more likely to qualify than at 30 minutes; one home-services analysis found 95% of companies don't respond within 5 minutes. Most CRMs send an autoresponder and stop.
- **Qualification is guesswork.** No major platform scores a lead with real property data (home value, age, permit history) before someone drives out.
- **The relationship ends at the final invoice.** 35–80% of business is repeats and referrals, yet post-job life is a warranty ticket at best. No referral attribution, no partner scoreboards, no home-anniversary or maintenance program.
- **Marketing and sales are disconnected.** Nobody can say "this Google campaign produced $410k of signed contracts," and nobody feeds signed revenue back to Google/Meta so their ad bidding improves.
- **They are hard to adopt.** "I absolutely hate it but I need to have it" (BuildBook survey title) sums up the category. Owners pay for features their team never uses.

Part 3: An automation-first CRM

> **Positioning:** the **self-running operating system** for design-build remodelers. Eagle I handles everything from "this house might need us" to "signed construction contract," plus the lifetime relationship afterward, and **does the work itself** instead of reminding someone to do it. It is **self-standing**: estimating, contracts, production, the homeowner portal and payments all live inside Eagle I, with no Buildertrend, JobTread or Houzz Pro needed. **The test for every feature:** after setup, does the client have to touch it? If yes, why can't the system do it?

The competitors automate *reminders*: they tell a person that a follow-up is due. Eagle I should automate the *follow-up itself*. The client's job shrinks to what only they can do: meet the homeowner, design, price, build, and make judgment calls. Everything else runs in the background and reports what it did.

Six rules that make this work

- **Approve once, run forever.** The owner approves each playbook one time: the wording, the timing, the limits. After that every instance runs on its own. This keeps Eagle I's “nothing sends without approval” promise without a click per message.
- **Events move the pipeline, not people.** A signed design agreement, a paid deposit, a booked visit, a reply or a call moves the deal to the next stage. Nobody drags cards or updates statuses.
- **Nobody types data.** Leads arrive pre-filled. Property details come from county records. Notes come from voice memos and call summaries. Contacts come from email signatures and forms.
- **The inbox shows only exceptions.** The client sees only what needs a person: a hot lead asking for a call, an unhappy reply, a stalled $200k deal, a proposal to price. Routine work never shows up there.
- **Guardrails are built in.** Quiet hours, daily caps, stop-on-reply, opt-outs, spend ceilings and a pause switch on every playbook. Eagle I already has all of these for email.
- **Every automation shows its work.** A weekly “what Eagle I did for you” summary: leads answered, median response time, visits booked, follow-ups sent, reviews requested, hours saved. If clients can't see the automation, they don't value it.

The automation map: what runs itself at every stage

Stage	Trigger	What Eagle I does automatically	What the client does
Find	Weekly permit, home-age, storm and Reddit data	Scores homes against the client's ideal job, queues mailers within the approved monthly budget, runs neighbor-radius ads around every won job, nudges referral partners who've gone quiet	Nothing; sets a budget once
Capture	Form, call, text, email, Houzz/Angi/Thumbtack lead email	Creates one contact + house + deal record, removes duplicates, adds county value and year built, tags the source	Nothing
Respond	Any new lead, 24/7	Text + email in under 60 seconds in the firm's voice; missed calls get an instant text-back; the owner gets an alert	Nothing
Qualify	Homeowner replies	AI asks scope, timeline, budget range and decision-makers; combines answers with property data into an A/B/C fit; C leads get a polite nurture or referral automatically	Nothing
Book	Fit A/B	Offers site-visit slots from the estimator's calendar, confirms, sends reminders (24 h, 2 h, “on my way”), emails the estimator a pre-visit brief	Show up
After visit	Calendar event ends	Turns a voice memo into notes, deal value and next steps; drafts the design agreement from a template; follows up if unsigned	One tap to review and send
Nurture	Deal sits longer than the firm's average	Sends an approved-playbook nudge; escalates to the owner only if it's high value or the reply is negative	Only escalations
Sign	E-signature + deposit paid	Advances the stage, sends a receipt and welcome sequence, turns the signed estimate into the job budget and schedule inside Eagle I, books the kickoff meeting	Nothing
Lost	Marked lost or 60 days silent	One-tap loss reason + competitor; automatic re-engagement in 6 months; feeds win/loss reports	One tap
During job	Weekly / payment milestone	AI progress update to the homeowner from photos and logs; payment-due reminders; mid-job check-in	Glance and approve
Complete	Final payment	Review request at the happiest moment, photo request, home file generated, portfolio post drafted and scheduled, neighbor mailer queued	Nothing
Lifetime	Calendar + systems installed	30-day and 1-year warranty check-ins, anniversary notes, seasonal maintenance reminders, referral asks, partner thank-yous; referrals arrive as new leads with credit	Nothing

Stage	Trigger	What Eagle I does automatically	What the client does
Marketing loop	Contract signed / backlog changes	Sends signed revenue to Google and Meta so ads optimize for jobs; slows spend when backlog is full and raises it when the pipeline thins (within limits)	Reads the monthly report

Where a person stays in the loop on purpose

Automating everything is not the goal. The goal is that the client only spends time where their judgment is worth money. Keep these manual, because they build trust and the incumbents' billing complaints show what happens without them:

- The first approval of every playbook, and any change to it.
- Pricing on proposals and contracts (AI drafts, a person sets the number).
- Replies that are negative, angry or legal in tone; these go straight to the owner and pause automations for that contact.
- Spending above the approved budget or any new paid channel.
- Anything legally binding (contracts, change orders, lien waivers).

Automate the setup too

Buildertrend's most common complaint is “massive onboarding.” The setup should run itself as well:

- **A 10-minute interview builds the account:** AI asks how they sell (design agreement or not, typical job size, service area) and builds the pipeline stages, playbooks and message wording in their voice.
- **Pre-filled from public data:** license, service area, project types and past projects pulled from the website, Google profile and state records (Eagle I already does most of this).
- **One-click switch-over:** import contacts, jobs and cost items from the CSV exports of their current CRM, Buildertrend, JobTread, spreadsheets and Gmail contacts (a one-time move, not an ongoing connection), with past clients enrolled in the lifetime program automatically.
- **Connect once:** Gmail/Outlook, calendar, phone number, Houzz/Angi lead emails. Target: live the same day, first automated lead response within 24 hours.

Automation vs. the leaders

Job to be done	Buildertrend / JobTread / Houzz Pro	Eagle I target
Find new jobs	Not offered (Houzz sells marketplace leads)	Runs weekly from permits, home data, storms, partners
First response	Autoresponder email at best	Two-way text + AI qualifier in under 60 s, around the clock
Book the site visit	Manual	Self-booking on the estimator's calendar with reminders
Follow-up	Task reminder for a person	Sent automatically from an approved playbook
Pipeline updates	Manual status changes	Driven by signatures, payments, replies, calendar
Client updates during job	Buildertrend: AI drafts (new Sep 2026)	AI drafts + scheduled sends under approve-once
Reviews, referrals, repeat work	Mostly manual	Fully automated lifetime program with attribution
Marketing ROI	Not connected	Signed revenue fed back to ads; spend follows backlog
Onboarding	Weeks, often paid setup	Same day, AI-built

Build order: one self-standing platform

Standalone means Eagle I has to cover what Buildertrend and JobTread do (estimates, schedules, budgets, change orders, the homeowner portal, invoicing), not just the sales side. The order below starts where Eagle I is already strongest and nobody else competes, then adds the production and money modules in the order a remodeler needs them. The only outside connections are the basic ones every business has (email, calendar, phone, card payments, ad accounts), plus a CSV export for the accountant.

Phase	What ships	Why this order
1. CRM core + automation engine (built, not yet live)	Contact + house + deal record; design-build pipeline; approve-once playbooks with guardrails; stop-on-reply; "Needs you" exceptions inbox; weekly "what Eagle I did" email	The base every later phase writes into. Landing-page leads flow in automatically from day one
2. Speed-to-lead autopilot	Two-way SMS (10DLC), missed-call text-back, Houzz/Angi/Thumbtack lead-email parsing, AI qualifier, self-booking with reminders, property-aware fit score	The biggest measurable win and the clearest gap in every competitor
3. Estimates, proposals, contracts	Cost catalog, AI-drafted estimates, paid design agreement, branded proposal, e-signature, Stripe deposits	Closes the sale inside Eagle I; the signed estimate becomes the job
4. Production	Job schedule, tasks, daily logs + photos, subs and vendors (from the verified directories already built), purchase orders, change orders with e-signature, selections and allowances	Replaces Buildertrend/JobTread for running the job
5. Homeowner portal	Status, photos, documents, selections, change-order approval, payments, AI weekly updates	The feature reviewers love most in the leaders; built on phases 3–4
6. Money	Budget vs. actual job costing, progress invoicing, online payments, AI receipt/bill capture, CSV export for the accountant	Profit visible during the job, not after
7. Lifetime program	Home file, warranty and maintenance sequences, referral links, partner scoreboard	Repeat and referral business on autopilot
8. Revenue loop	Source-to-signed-$ attribution, offline conversions to Google/Meta, backlog-aware ad spend	Marketing that tunes itself to how busy the firm is
9. Same-day onboarding	AI setup interview, public-data prefill, one-time CSV import from their old tools	Makes switching off Buildertrend/JobTread painless

Phase 1 in detail

Goal: every lead lands in one pipeline on its own, routine follow-up sends itself under rules the owner approved once, and the owner only looks at what needs them.

Piece	What it does
Records	Contact (person), property (the house, with the county median home value for its Houston ZIP), deal (stage, value, source), and a timeline of every note, stage move, email and reply.
Pipeline	Design-build stages: New → Qualified → Site visit → Design agreement sent → In design → Proposal sent → Contract signed → In production → Complete, plus Lost. Works as a stage list on a phone.
Automatic intake	Every landing-page lead becomes a contact + deal in New, matched to an existing contact by email or phone. Existing leads are brought in the first time the pipeline opens.
Playbooks	Starter set: site-visit prep, design-agreement follow-up, proposal follow-up, welcome aboard, job-complete thank-you and 30-day check-in, lost-deal check-back after 6 months. Each starts off and runs only after the owner approves the exact wording; any edit needs a fresh approval.
Guardrails	Stops when the deal leaves the stage, when the person replies, unsubscribes or bounces; business-hours sending; daily cap; one switch pauses everything; unsubscribe link and address on every email.
Needs you	Exceptions only: a new lead nobody has touched in 30 minutes, a deal stuck in a stage, a reply to an automated email (flagged if negative), or an email that failed to send. Mark done or snooze.

Piece	What it does
Weekly summary	Monday email: new leads, how fast they were picked up, automated emails sent, replies, deals moved and signed, open pipeline value. Counts come from real records only.
Stays in sync	Moving a deal updates the old Leads inbox status (and stops the new-lead emails), and the other way round.

Not in Phase 1: SMS, calendar booking, proposals/e-signature, custom stages, multiple users per company. Those land in phases 2–4.

Validate with Levi Homes before building: (1) Which tasks eat the most of their week today (lead follow-up, scheduling, client updates, paperwork)? Automate those first. (2) Their real pipeline stages, and whether they sell a paid design agreement. (3) Average lead response time and close rate, if known. (4) Share of revenue from repeats, referrals and trade partners. (5) What they would never want sent without seeing it; that sets the approve-once boundaries. (6) Which tool they use today for estimates and job management, and what it would take to switch off it.

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